

Phoenicopterus roseus

Greater flamingo



Height 5 ft
(1.5 m)

Weight Up to 8¼ lb
(4 kg)

Plumage Sexes alike

Migration Partial migrant

Status Least concern

Location Central America,
South America, Caribbean,
S.W. Europe, Asia, Africa

With its exceptionally long neck and legs, the greater flamingo is the largest member of the flamingo family. It is found in a wide variety of freshwater and saline habitats, particularly salt lakes, estuaries, and lagoons. Greater flamingos outside the tropics often migrate to warmer regions for winter,

and in all regions they fly long distances—sometimes up to 300 miles (500 km)—to find food, traveling at night. The greater flamingo’s large size enables it to wade out into relatively deep water, whereas other flamingos are restricted to the shallows; it also sometimes swims, up-ending like a duck in order to reach food. This flamingo usually feeds with its head fully immersed, sometimes keeping it underwater for up to 20 seconds. Unlike smaller flamingos, it rarely takes food from the surface, which reduces competition with them. Diet is varied, and includes insects, worms, microscopic algae, and pieces of vegetation. The greater flamingo feeds mainly during the day, even in the hottest conditions. Highly gregarious, it breeds in colonies of up to 200,000 monogamous pairs. Courtship involves

MASS BREEDING

For a social species, the greater flamingo shows a remarkable range of colony size. In some parts of the world, breeding colonies contain huge numbers of birds, but in others—such as southern Europe—they may contain only a few dozen. This variability is one of the reasons why greater flamingos, unlike some of their relatives, are relatively easy to breed in captivity.



NESTS AND CHICKS

As with all flamingos, nests of greater flamingos are flattened cones of mud, often surrounded by a shallow “moat,” and spaced about 5 ft (1.5 m) apart, just beyond pecking distance. Both parents incubate the single egg. They defend the nest when breeding, but are otherwise nonterritorial. Once the chicks can walk, they gather in large creches under the supervision of a small number of adults.



Phoenicoparrus jamesi

James’s flamingo



Height 3½ ft
(1.1 m)

Weight 4½ lb
(2 kg)

Plumage Sexes alike

Migration Nonmigrant

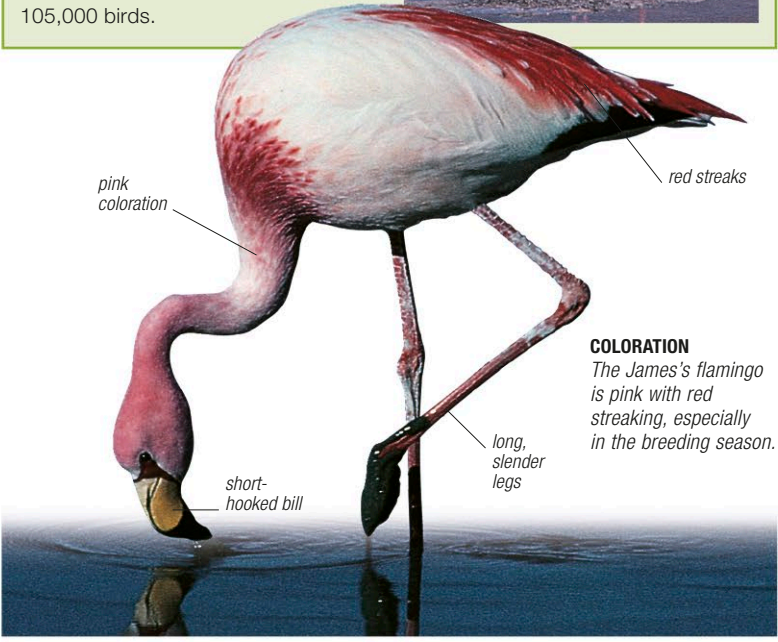
Status Near threatened

Location W. South
America

An alternative name for this flamingo, puna flamingo, derives from a local word for a high Andean plateau. Its diet consists of diatoms—microscopic algae that abound in salt lakes. It feeds by day in shallow water, walking slowly forward with its bill dipped just under the water surface. Diatoms are filtered out of the water in the bill and swallowed. This flamingo has a variety of calls, both when feeding and on the wing. It is one of 3 South American flamingos, the other 2 being the Chilean flamingo (*Phoenicopterus chilensis*) and the Andean flamingo (*Phoenicoparrus andinus*). All 3 species can be found together in salt lakes, usually at altitudes over 9,900 ft (3,000 m). Most James’s flamingos migrate to lower altitudes in winter, but some remain at lakes where there are hot springs. The courtship and breeding habits of this bird are similar to those of the greater flamingo (see above).

CONSERVATION

With its small size and localized distribution, the James’s flamingo is vulnerable to anything that affects its reproductive success. In the past, its meat and eggs were widely used for food, and during the first half of the 20th century, it suffered a marked population decline. The major breeding colonies are protected, and its numbers have responded well. In 2010, the total population was estimated to stand at just over 105,000 birds.



Phoeniconaias minor

Lesser flamingo



Height Up to 3¼ ft
(1 m)

Weight Up to 4½ lb
(2 kg)

Plumage Sexes alike

Migration Nomadic

Status Near threatened

Location W., C., and
southern Africa

The smallest but most numerous flamingo, the lesser flamingo may be light to dark pink, with a relatively long, dark-colored beak. It is nonmigratory, but will readily move to a new site in search of food. Its diet consists almost entirely of microscopic blue-green algae, abundant in soda lakes. It feeds in shallow water at dusk and after dark, avoiding strong daytime winds. Some colonies are over a million strong—among the largest bird aggregations in the world. Courtship rituals often involve hundreds of birds moving and displaying in synchrony.

